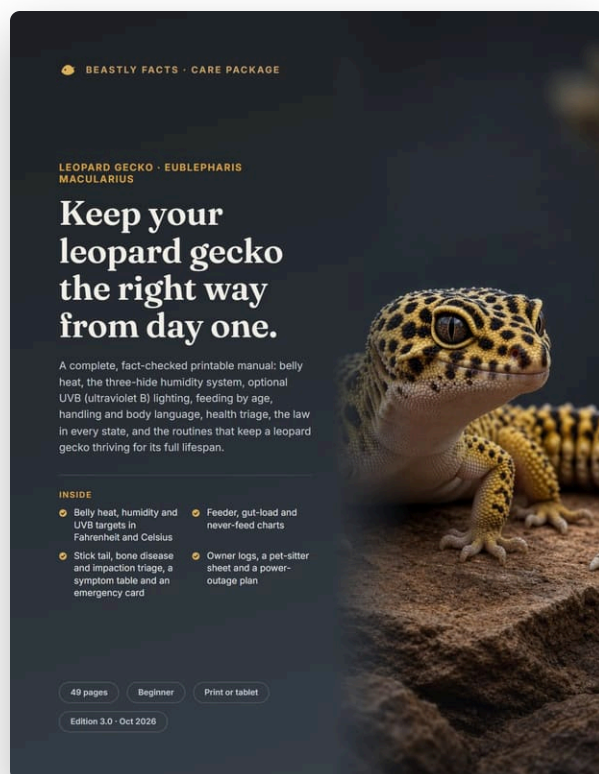


FREE SAMPLE

Leopard Gecko Care Package

The first 5 pages of the 49-page printable manual, free to keep.



In this sample: What's inside, How to Use This Package, Quick Profile & Cost Overview, The Species, Morphs, Size & Lifespan. The contents page shows every one of the 49 pages, so you can see exactly what the full package covers before you buy it.

Not in this sample: the 44 pages that follow, which are the full care guide, the health section, the quick reference cards, and the owner tools, checklists and logs.

The full package is \$8.99 at beastlyfacts.com/care-packages/leopard-gecko/. One purchase, and every corrected edition is a free re-download from your library. The free leopard gecko care guide it was built from is at beastlyfacts.com/guides/leopard-gecko/, and stays free.

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice. Temperatures appear in degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C) beside them. Sizes appear in inches (in) with centimeters (cm) beside them, millimeters (mm) for the smallest insects, and tank sizes in gallons, the way they are sold. A gecko and its weight log are measured in grams (g), the unit a kitchen scale shows. Humidity is a percentage (%) of the moisture the air could hold. Prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't set up yet

Check the law first, on page 26: a leopard gecko is legal without a permit in most of the United States, but not everywhere. Then read pages 4 to 11 in order before buying anything. The enclosure size and the three-hide layout decide most of what goes in the cart, and the thermostat is never optional. Use the Budget & Shopping List on page 36 to buy once.

If your gecko is already home

Audit what you have against the Setup Checklist in the print list below, and go to the Red Flags page (page 27) if anything seems off. Read the warm hide floor with an infrared thermometer before you change anything else: a warm side running too cool explains more refused meals than any other fixable cause, and the feeding pages starting on page 12 show why.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Page 34: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 41: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 35: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 42: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 38: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 43: Equipment & Vet Log |
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WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Leopard geckos are sold as the easy reptile, and the setup sold with one is often years out of date: a 20 gallon tank, calcium sand, one hide, no thermostat, no UVB. This package reflects current enclosure-size, heating, humidity and diet standards, cross-checked against the veterinary and scientific sources listed on page 47.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A reptile-experienced veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is always a vet call, not a page in this book. Find a reptile vet before you need one and write the number on the emergency card. Nothing on the law page is legal advice either.

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Eublepharis macularius</i>
Adult size	6 to 9 in (15 to 23 cm) nose to tail; males 60 to 90 g, females as light as 45 g
Captive lifespan	10 to 20 years with proper care, and some reach 25 to 30
Native range	Rocky desert, arid grassland and dry scrub in Pakistan, Afghanistan, Iran, India and Nepal
Diet type	Obligate insectivore: live insects, no fruit or vegetables (page 12)
Active	At dusk and dawn (crepuscular), so evening is feeding and handling time
Enclosure minimum (adult)	36×18×18 in (91×46×46 cm), front-opening preferred; floor space matters more than height
Heat	An under-tank heat mat on a thermostat, 88 to 92°F (31 to 33°C) on the warm hide floor
UVB	Optional but beneficial, kept low: a UVI (ultraviolet index, the strength of the UVB) of 0.6 to 1.4 at the basking spot
Handling difficulty	Beginner; tolerant once settled, and never picked up by the tail
Conservation status	Least Concern, the lowest-risk grade on the global list of threatened species

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$20 to \$45 for a pet-store gecko and \$175 to \$495 for the equipment, plus \$150 to \$215 for the first vet exam and fecal test (a stool check for parasites): \$325 to \$710 before the gecko. Every line is on page 36.

Monthly ongoing

\$20 to \$82: feeder insects, supplements, substrate, electricity and UVB tube replacement. The yearly wellness exam, \$85 to \$105, comes on top.

BUDGET FOR THE WORST CASE TOO

A sick or emergency visit runs \$100 to \$800 or more, and diagnostics or surgery push it higher again. Treat a small emergency fund as part of the setup cost, not an optional extra.

Fun facts worth knowing

- Unlike most geckos, leopard geckos have movable eyelids and can blink. They also lack the sticky toe pads other geckos climb glass with.
- The fat tail is the gecko's energy store. A plump tail means good condition, and a thinning one is often the first sign that something is wrong.
- The temperature an egg is incubated at decides the sex: cooler eggs hatch mostly females, warmer eggs mostly males, and the hottest eggs, about 93°F (34°C) and up, mostly females again.

The species, morphs, size & lifespan

What you are buying, how big it gets, and how long it stays.

One species

The pet leopard gecko is *Eublepharis macularius*. In the wild it lives across arid country from Pakistan to northwestern India, sheltering by day in rocky outcrops and dry grassland and coming out at dusk to hunt insects, scorpions, small lizards and worms. It is a ground dweller: no toe pads, no climbing glass, and a life spent on and under the floor, which is why floor space matters more than height in its enclosure. It is not a social species and does not do well sharing an enclosure, so every leopard gecko is housed alone.

Morphs

A morph is a captive-bred line that looks different from the natural, wild-type gecko: a different color or pattern. Over 100 are recognized. A standard or wild-type gecko costs \$20 to \$45 at a pet store; breeders often charge \$50 to \$150 even for a basic morph, popular morphs sit around \$75 to \$300, and rare designer morphs run \$500 to \$3,500 or more. The care in this package applies to every morph with one exception. Albino and other pale morphs burn more easily under UVB, so they get a UVI of 0.5 to 0.7 or lower instead of 0.6 to 1.4 (page 9).

Size

Adult length	6 to 9 in (15 to 23 cm) nose to tail tip.
Adult weight	Males 60 to 90 g. Females are lighter, some as light as 45 g. A gecko that drops its tail loses a large share of its reserves at once, which is why the tail matters so much in an animal this small.
Young geckos	A gecko under about 3 in (8 cm) long is fragile and easily injured. It waits until it reaches roughly 6 in (15 cm) before regular handling.
Counted as adult	Once the tail has thickened to about the width of the neck. That is the point it moves onto the adult feeding schedule (page 12).

Lifespan

10 to 20 years is typical in captivity with proper care, and some leopard geckos reach 25 to 30. Wild geckos manage 6 to 8 years, because predation, parasites and harsh conditions cut them short. At \$240 to \$984 a year in running costs, 10 to 20 years adds up to \$2,400 to \$19,680 before a single sick visit. A hatchling bought today may outlast its enclosure, its heat mat and several UVB tubes, so plan for the whole span: the routine and a reptile vet for every one of those years.

CAPTIVE-BRED IS THE ONLY KIND ON SALE

Leopard geckos were imported into the United States and Europe from Pakistan, Afghanistan and India through the 1960s and 1970s, and were being bred in the United States by the early 1970s.

Large-scale breeding started in the late 1980s, and the color morphs followed in the 1990s.

Essentially every leopard gecko sold today is captive-bred, with no wild-collected supply behind the pet trade. What to look for in the animal itself is on page 22.